‘It was nice meeting you, Mathur,’ Chohan said abruptly, indicating that the meeting was over.

Years later, recalling the encounter at a quiet cafe in Delhi, Mathur told me he had been nervous before the meeting but as he left the building, he realised that a man running a militant campaign from a safe house in Washington was as vulnerable from the inside as any other human being.

‘His image of a tough warrior was the creation of propagandists and partly the media. I would not say he was affable, but he was normal. We exchanged phone numbers and promised to keep in touch. For me, the primary task was to convince him to stop playing Pakistan’s game and I had a feeling that my first meeting was impressive. The government was working hard to end Sikh militancy and the R&AW’s job was to persuade and neutralise the pro-Khalistan elements abroad by any means,’ Mathur told me.

Around a week later, Mathur received a call. Jagjit Singh Chohan had something important to share. Rakesh Nagar, a junior R&AW officer who was part of Mathur’s team in Washington, made every effort to dissuade him from meeting Chohan again.

‘Nagar was really worried. He thought it was a trap to abduct and kill me to grab international headlines. He offered two bodyguards for my security, but I insisted on meeting Chohan alone. I had a feeling that Chohan was powerful and vulnerable at the same time. If I played my games perfectly, Chohan’s downfall was imminent,’ Mathur said.

The meeting took place at a pre-decided nondescript location. Unarmed and defenseless, Mathur was ushered into the room where Chohan was sitting, protected by his armed bodyguards.